

» BEST OF 2025 INDIA'S NEW HITMAN

Looks can be deceiving, and Abhishek Sharma is a classic example. With his neatly cropped hair and easy smile, he could pass for a college heartthrob, not a cold-blooded run machine. But judge him by appearances and the punishment is swift. Once he feels the bat in his hand, the softness vanishes, replaced by a ruthless clarity of intent that has made bowlers pay repeatedly.

In 2025, Abhishek set the tone early.

In February, against a formidable England attack featuring Jofra Archer and Mark Wood, during the fifth Twenty20 International at the Wankhede Stadium, Abhishek tore into pace and spin alike to smash a 37-ball hundred. He came within touching distance of Rohit Sharma's national record of a 35-ball century, set in 2017.

He eventually walked back with a colossal 135 off 54 balls, laced with 13 sixes and seven fours. The innings powered India to a 150-run victory, its second-biggest margin in T20Is, and vaulted Abhishek to the No. 1 spot in the ICC T20I batter rankings. In the process, he displaced

Sunrisers Hyderabad teammate Travis Head to become only the third Indian, after Virat Kohli and Suryakumar Yadav, to reach the summit.

His dominance carried into the Asia Cup, where he was named Player of the Tournament after amassing 314 runs, the most by any batter in a single edition.

In the Indian Premier League, Sunrisers Hyderabad retained him for Rs. 14 crore, and Punjab Kings bore the brunt. Abhishek announced himself with a ferocious 141 off 55 balls, the highest individual score by an Indian in IPL history and the third-highest overall, behind Chris Gayle and Brendon McCullum. He finished the season with 439 runs from 14 matches.

The defining thread of Abhishek's year was his appetite for clearing the ropes. On December 6, during a Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy match against Services, he crossed 100

T20 sixes in a calendar year, surpassing his own Indian record of 87 set in 2024.

As the year drew to a close, it was fair to say Abhishek, the second-highest run-scorer of 2025 in T20Is among ICC full-member nations, had quietly shifted the boundaries of what constitutes a safe total in the format.

Santadeep Dey

VIJAY SONEJI